Diagnostics waiting over six weeks

Forecast for September 2026 · data through August 2026

The latest Diagnostics waiting over six weeks result was 24.7%. For the next release, it is expected to improve to 23.7%. The model's expected improvement is mainly due to the usual month-to-month seasonal movement; the underlying trend is broadly flat. The current projection is off course for 14% or less by March 2027. Across providers, sustained favourable signals outnumber adverse ones (49 to 44).

LATEST · AUGUST 2026	FORECAST · SEPTEMBER 2026	ACTUAL
24.7%	**23.7%**	—
0.5pp below forecast	80% expected range 21.2%–25.6%	Not yet released
		Off course · 14% or less by March 2027

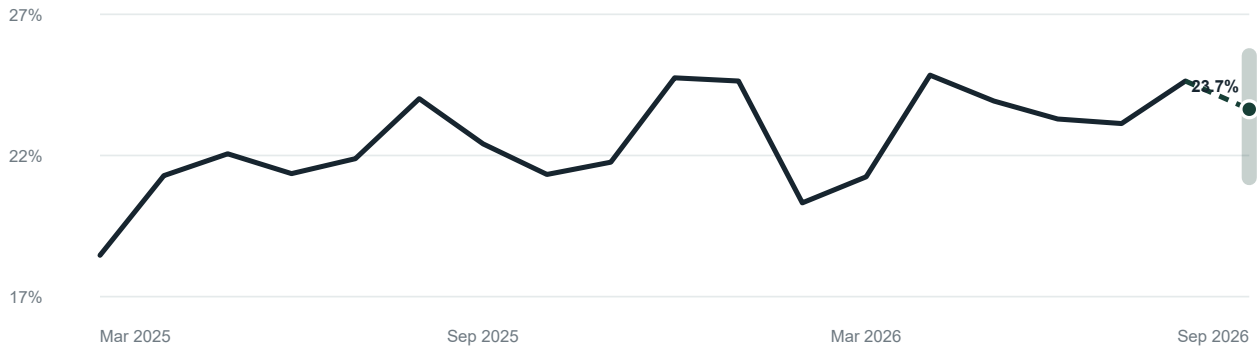
WHAT CHANGED?

Diagnostics waiting over six weeks deteriorated in the latest month. Total diagnostic waiting list changed by -88,062, while People waiting over six weeks changed by +7,806. The percentage therefore reflects both the size of the cohort and how many were within the standard.

Monthly	Annual	Total diagnostic waiting list
+1.5pp	+0.6pp	-88,062

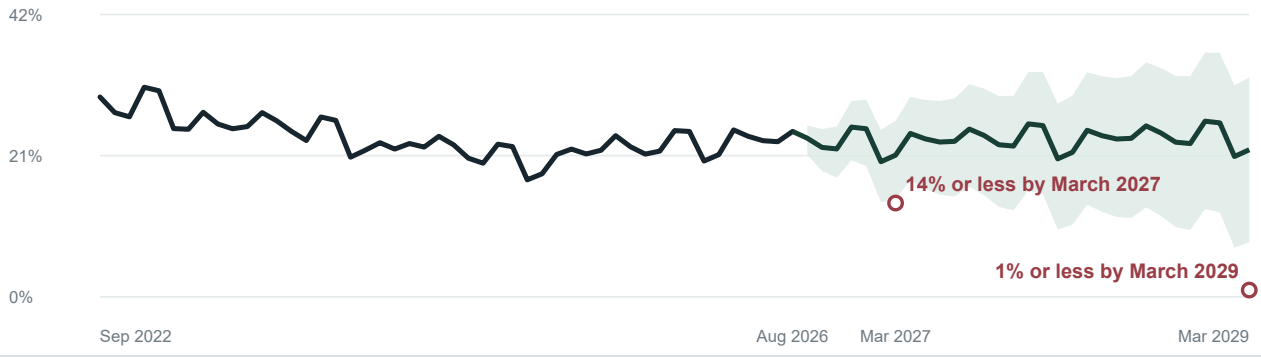
Recent performance and next release

The vertical band is the 80% expected range.



Longer-term outlook and milestones

Descriptive projection; not forced to meet targets.



Benchmark: 1% operational standard. 7.1pp above milestone

Data: NHS England diagnostic waiting times and activity. **Targets:** Medium Term Planning Framework national target · Medium Term Planning Framework final target

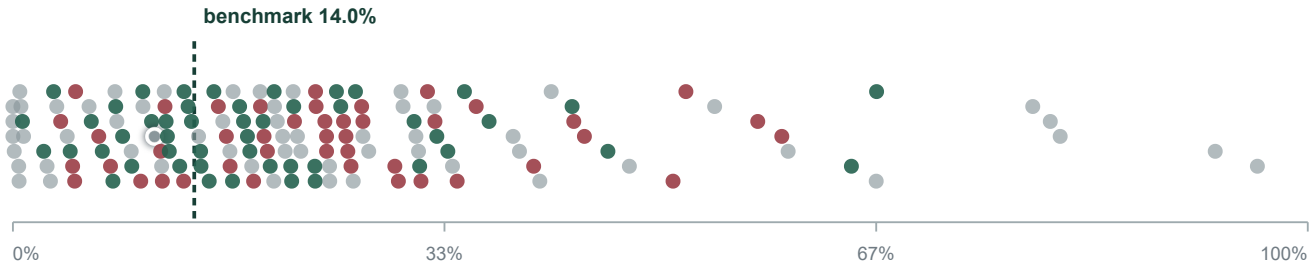
Method: Backtest-weighted ensemble of current-level seasonal movement, damped annual drift and a damped recent seasonal trend; at least 2 components are required. The final fit uses 248 consecutive months. Accuracy is tested on 36 rolling one-month-ahead forecasts. The 80% range uses empirical historical error quantiles from 36 forecast errors. Weights use inverse rolling RMSE and are shrunk toward equal weights. The pre-release commentary compares the current-level seasonal component with the combined forecast. Provider distribution and trajectory watch are shown on page 2.

Diagnostics waiting over six weeks

Distribution and trajectory watch · August 2026

Provider distribution

Latest reported performance across providers. This is a comparison of current levels, not a measure of whether each provider is improving or deteriorating.

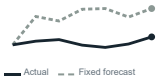


Trajectory watch

Six actual months are compared with one forecast path fixed before that window. Both lines begin at the same observed value. A low performer can be improving, while a high performer can be deteriorating. Status: Actual performance is compared with the monthly path forecast six months earlier. The displayed figure is the average gap across those six months.

142	49	44	49
providers assessed	sustained favourable	sustained adverse	without an active signal

Largest sustained favourable moves

West London NHS Trust
Latest 64.8% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


35.3pp
BETTER THAN FIXED PATH

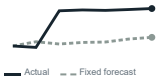
Royal Surrey NHS Foundation Trust
Latest 12.1% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


31.5pp
BETTER THAN FIXED PATH

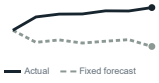
King's College Hospital NHS Foundation Trust
Latest 19.9% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


26.0pp
BETTER THAN FIXED PATH

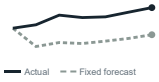
Largest sustained adverse moves

Royal Papworth Hospital NHS Foundation Trust
Latest 59.4% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


34.9pp
WORSE THAN FIXED PATH

Dorset Healthcare University NHS Foundation Trust
Latest 34.3% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


21.0pp
WORSE THAN FIXED PATH

East Kent Hospitals University NHS Foundation Trust
Latest 52.0% · 6 months compared with a path fixed six months earlier
Forecast fixed before the six-month window


19.9pp
WORSE THAN FIXED PATH

Trajectory-watch rule. Six actual months are compared with the corresponding path fixed before the six-month window. A signal requires a material average gap, at least five of six months in the same direction, and the latest month confirming that direction. These are screening prompts—not league tables, causal estimates or judgements of provider quality.